



**Ministers cited
India's growth rate,
telling Americans,
your money is
safer with us.**



**SHOW TIME: (Clockwise from left)
A city bus, Bryant Park, Indian policy
makers with Kissinger, a hoarding**

out by Colonial Cousins.

Dancers and musicians from all over India gathered in several little slices of Manhattan to perform. There were displays and demonstrations of Indian handicrafts and handlooms. At Bryant Park and on a vessel anchored off Chelsea Piers, chefs from around the country held culinary demonstrations that gave Americans a taste of India. Among those who dropped by, taking time off from duty at the UN, were the foreign ministers of Brazil, South Africa, Australia and Iran, who wanted India's tourism authorities to hold similar road shows in their countries. Said Amitabh Kant, joint secretary, Ministry of Tourism: "Instead of spreading out events, we thought it would be a better idea to do something that creates a bang. And New Yorkers, as you can see, have responded."

But IncredibleIndia@60 was not just about tourism. Tarun Das, chief mentor of CII, said the idea was born out of the successful "India Everywhere" campaign in Davos last year. "The UNGA is the time when the world comes to New York," said Das, explaining the rationale behind holding the event in New York. He was part of a high-level dele-

gation that included, among others, Bharti's Sunil Mittal, Infosys's Nandan Nilekani and TVS's Venu Srinivasan. When speaker after speaker noted, at the inaugural as well as in subsequent events at Yale and Columbia universities and several other venues across the city, that 'India at 60' was a perfect example of freedom and 9-per-cent growth co-existing, there was no mistaking the zeal to persuade American executives that the country's free-wheeling democracy remains a plus.

At different venues, the half dozen visiting ministers said the same thing: it's the fastest growing telecom market in the world; billions are being invested in its infrastructure; foreign exchange reserves are in excess of \$220 billion (Rs 8,80,000 crore); merchandise exports have crossed \$125 billion (Rs 5,00,000 crore) while IT exports are about a third of that; the country attracted FDI of nearly \$20 billion (Rs 80,000 crore) last year. In short, they were telling the Americans: your money is safer with us.

Tourism has taken giant strides in recent years, with arrivals growing by over 90 per cent in the last five years, while foreign exchange earnings have gone up by 125 per cent in the same period. The sector's contribution to the Indian economy stands at 5.9 per cent and employment in the sector is 41.8 million, or 8.8 per cent of total employment. It is one of the largest net foreign exchange earners, recording over \$6.6 billion (Rs 26,400 crore) last year.

Americans are intrepid travellers. Last year, 30 million travelled abroad, spending \$60 billion (Rs 2,40,000 crore). Of these, barely eight lakh or 2.6 per cent visited India, an abysmal figure for a country that has everything to offer on a round-the-year basis. The scale of IncredibleIndia@60 is a reflection of the importance that India attaches to the US market. Americans are not only the world's largest outbound travellers, they also have the highest per capita spend and the highest duration of stay per traveller in India. If the industry is able to build on the momentum generated by the campaign, it would get a much-needed fillip. And the new wave of American tourists will discover that India is not just incredible. India also means business. ■

midnight, in the city that never sleeps, citizens and tourists alike gaped at the 100-ft-plus tall, illuminated scrollers on the Nasdaq and Reuters buildings, inviting Americans—and indeed the world—to discover what was repeatedly emphasised as the "world's fastest growing free market economy". At over 40 venues across Manhattan, nearly 270 artistes and craftsmen, folk dancers and chefs from Mumbai to Mizoram and Kashmir to Kerala, put on a display that truly dazzled the eye.

For sheer colour and variety, the event was like nothing New York had seen before. Passengers alighting at the Grand Central railway station—which, occupying 49 acres, is the world's largest—were greeted by artistes performing Kathakali and Mohiniattam at its cavernous entrance. Orissa's sandman Sudarshan Patnaik wasn't happy with the quality of the sand provided to him to replicate the Taj Mahal at the Port Authority Bus Station, so he ordered another 1,600 bags just so he could get the right mix. Percussionist Sivamani brought traffic to a standstill at Times Square, and elsewhere, New Yorkers clapped and danced to the beat of rock from Remo Fernandes. After office hours, executives in pinstripes headed for Bryant Park on 42nd Street, where they swayed to the music belted